

SUCH A BAD GIRLFRIEND II

THE SECRET BEHIND MY GOOD-GIRL ACT *PART II*



JJ VALE

Such a Bad Girlfriend II

The secret behind my good-girl act Part 2

JJ Vale

PMI

Copyright © 2026 JJ Vale

All rights reserved

The characters and events portrayed in this book are fictitious. Any similarity to real persons, living or dead, is coincidental and not intended by the author.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without express written permission of the publisher.

My boyfriend Owen kissed me goodbye at the door, reminding me that he'd be home late, some presentation for potential research funders that the whole lab had to attend. "Probably seven or eight," he said, adjusting his messenger bag on his shoulder. "Don't wait on dinner for me."

"Good luck with the presentation," I said. "They'll love you."

"It's mostly Derek presenting, but thanks." Another kiss, this one quicker. "Love you."

"Love you."

The door closed, and I was alone.

I stood there for a moment in the quiet apartment, coffee mug warming my hands, listening to the silence. This was my favorite time, actually, these pockets of solitude when I didn't have to perform for anyone. When I could just exist without curating my expressions or moderating my tone or thinking three moves ahead.

I took my coffee to the couch and curled up in the corner, pulling the blanket over my legs. My laptop was on the coffee table where I'd left it yesterday. I should check my work email, get a head start on the day before I needed to actually be in the office at ten.

Instead, I opened Instagram. Scrolled through the morning's posts, someone's workout selfie, a food blogger's elaborate breakfast spread, an engagement announcement from a girl I'd gone to high school with who I barely remembered. I double-tapped on the appropriate ones, kept scrolling.

Brady had posted a story. I hesitated for a second. Watching his stories created a data trail, a tiny digital footprint, but curiosity won. I tapped on his profile picture.

It was a video from the climbing gym, showing him demonstrating some technique to a student, his voice encouraging and patient: "There you go, shift your weight left, use your legs not your arms." He was good at his job, I realized. Genuinely good at teaching, at making people feel capable.

The next slide was a photo of a protein shake and a caption: "Post-workout fuel."

Basic. Predictable. He was probably exactly who he appeared to be, a straightforward guy who liked climbing and working out and sending flirty texts to the hot girl he was sleeping with.

No complexity. No hidden depths. That was part of the appeal, I suppose.

I closed Instagram and opened my messages with him instead. The thread was carefully managed on my end, I deleted conversations regularly, never let them build up into anything that could be stumbled upon. His messages were more frequent, more eager.

I typed: *Can't do the usual hotel Thursday. How about somewhere different? That place downtown with the rooftop bar?*

I watched the three dots appear almost immediately. He was online, probably on a break between clients.

Brady: *The Morrison? Fancy. You trying to impress me?*

Me: *Maybe I just want a change of scenery*

Brady: *Works for me. Same time?*

Me: *1pm. I'll book it*

Brady: *Can't wait. Been thinking about you*

I didn't respond to that. Instead, I switched over to the hotel booking site and found the Morrison. Available Thursday, one king bed, rooftop access included. More expensive than our usual spot, nearly twice as much, but I could put it on my credit card, the one Owen never saw the bills for because we kept our finances mostly separate. He paid the rent and utilities; I paid for groceries and my own expenses. Clean. Compartmentalized.

I booked the room under my name. Confirmation number, email receipt. I'd delete the email later.

The coffee had gone lukewarm. I got up to make another, and while the espresso machine hissed and steamed, I finally opened my work laptop and scanned through emails. The client meeting had indeed moved, from three-thirty Thursday to two-thirty. My stomach did a small flip before I calculated the new logistics.

Hotel at one. Seventy-five minutes with Brady, out by two-fifteen at the absolute latest. The Morrison was only fifteen minutes from the client's office. I could do it. Tight, but doable.

I'd just have to make sure Brady understood we were on a strict timeline. No lingering, no post-sex conversation. In and out. I even liked it better like

that. The phrasing made me smile into my coffee mug.

My boss had also sent a message about the creative review meeting that afternoon, could I present the revised concepts for the boutique hotel campaign? I typed back a confirmation, then opened the presentation deck to review it.

The work was good. I was good at my job, actually. I had an eye for what would appeal to people, how to craft a message that would land, what story to tell to make someone want something. The boutique hotel chain wanted to position themselves as "authentic luxury", whatever that meant, and I'd built a whole campaign around the idea of intimate experiences, secret spaces, moments stolen from ordinary life.

The irony wasn't lost on me.

I worked for the next hour, refining slides, tweaking copy, making everything sharp and polished. At nine-fifteen, I finally got up to shower and get ready for the office.

In the bathroom, I studied myself in the mirror while the water heated. My skin looked good. I'd been religious about my skincare routine lately, the expensive serums and retinols that actually made a difference. My hair needed washing. My body looked the same as always: toned from climbing, curved in the right places, the kind of body that photographed well and attracted attention.

I wondered sometimes if I'd be doing this, the cheating, the lying, the elaborate constructions, if I were less attractive. If the world responded to me differently, would I respond to it differently?

Probably not. The looks were just a tool, like anything else. I'd still want the thrill, the secret power, the proof that I could move through the world taking what I wanted without consequence.

The shower was hot and quick this time, functional rather than meditative. I washed efficiently, dried off, and stood in my towel in front of the closet, considering options.

I pulled out a black sleeveless turtleneck, expensive, fitted, the kind that looked effortlessly sophisticated, and paired it with high-waisted gray trousers. Professional but striking. I added a thin gold necklace, small hoop earrings, the rings I always wore. My makeup was precise: foundation, subtle contouring, a nude lip, mascara that made my lashes look twice as long.

The woman looking back at me from the mirror was successful, put-together, the kind of person you'd trust with your marketing budget or your secrets.

I took a photo, just my outfit, angled down from my chin, showing the clean lines and the casual perfection of it, and posted it to Instagram with the caption: "Presentation day."

The likes started coming in before I'd even left the bathroom.

The office was a twenty-minute drive, longer if traffic was bad. I grabbed my laptop bag, my presentation notes, the half-finished coffee I'd made earlier, and locked the apartment behind me.

In the car, I queued up a podcast, something about true crime, a woman's voice describing a murder in meticulous detail, and let it play while I navigated morning traffic. I wasn't really listening. My mind was already in the conference room, visualizing the presentation, anticipating questions, planning responses.

I was good at this part. The professional act came as naturally as any other.

The agency was in a renovated warehouse building downtown, all exposed brick and industrial lighting and standing desks. I'd been there for two years, worked my way up from junior designer to creative lead on several major accounts. My boss, Miranda, was a sharp woman in her forties who wore statement glasses and had a reputation for being difficult but fair.

She liked me. I'd made sure of that.

"Natalie!" She caught me as I was settling into my desk. "Got your email. The concepts look fantastic from what I saw in the preview. Client's going to eat it up."

"Thanks. I'm feeling good about it."

"Two-thirty, right? You need the big conference room?"

"Already booked it."

"Perfect. Oh, and remind me, we need to talk about the Peterson account next week. I'm thinking you might be right for lead on that one."

A promotion, essentially. More responsibility, more visibility, more money. "Absolutely. Just let me know when."

Miranda moved on to terrorize someone else, and I opened my laptop, pulling up the presentation one more time. Around me, the office was

coming to life, designers at their monitors, account managers on calls, the espresso machine in the kitchen hissing constantly.

My phone buzzed. Owen: *Good morning again. Forgot to tell you, Mom asked if we're free for dinner Sunday. No pressure if you're not up for it*

Owen's mother was nice in that particular way that felt like an act of niceness. She smiled a lot and asked polite questions and I could never tell if she actually liked me or if she was just being civil for Owen's sake. She might have been too much like me. His father was easier, quiet, academic, perfectly content to talk about research or books or nothing at all.

Me: *Sunday works for me. What time?*

Owen: *I'll ask. Probably 6. You're the best*

Owen: *Also you looked beautiful this morning. Forgot to tell you that too*

Me: *You're sweet. Good luck today*

I put the phone away and focused on work. Answered emails, reviewed some junior designer's mockups for another project, joined a brainstorming call for a potential new client. The morning dissolved into the rhythm of it, the comfortable flow of tasks and conversations and small decisions.

At eleven-thirty, I took a break to scroll through my phone. Brady had liked my Instagram post from this morning, of course he had, and sent a direct message: *You look incredible. It can't come fast enough*

I didn't respond. Let him wait. Let him wonder.

Jessica had texted back about drinks: *Tuesday works! 7pm at that wine bar near your place?*

Me: *Perfect, see you then*

I'd actually meet her, I decided. It would be good to have a real alibi for once, something Owen could verify if he ever got suspicious. Not that he would. But still. Better to maintain the infrastructure.

Lunch was a salad from the place downstairs, eaten at my desk while I polished the presentation slides one more time. Changed one word in the third slide. Adjusted the spacing on the fifth. Perfection was in the details.

At two o'clock, I gathered my things and headed to the conference room. It was the nice one, with the big windows overlooking the street, the expensive table, the screen for presentations. I connected my laptop and pulled up the deck, testing the display.

Miranda arrived first, then David from account management, then two people from the client's team via video call, a marketing director named Sharon and her associate whose name I'd forgotten.

"Natalie, wonderful to see you again," Sharon said through the screen, her face pixelated slightly.

"You too, Sharon. I think you're going to love what we've put together."

And then I presented. I was good at this, the semblance of confidence, the careful modulation of my voice, the knowing exactly when to pause, when to smile, when to invite questions. I walked them through the strategy, the creative concepts, the execution plan. I watched their faces, read their reactions, adjusted my energy accordingly.

Sharon loved the tagline. David jumped in with supporting data. Miranda nodded approvingly from her seat by the window.

By two-fifty, we had their approval to move forward.

"Fantastic work," Miranda said after the call ended. "Seriously, Natalie. You nailed it."

"Thanks. It's a good campaign."

"It's a great campaign. Drinks on me Friday to celebrate?"

"I'm there."

I packed up my laptop riding the high of a successful presentation, and checked my phone. One message from Owen: *How did it go???*

Me: *Killed it. They loved everything*

Owen: *Knew you would. So proud of you*

The pride was genuine. He really was proud, really did believe in my competence, my talent.

Thursday came with unseasonable heat, the kind that made the city shimmer and stuck clothing to skin. I'd chosen my outfit carefully that morning while Owen was still in the shower, a white silk blouse that draped perfectly, black cigarette skirt that hugged my hips, heels that added three inches and made my legs look endless. Professional enough for the client meeting. Sexy enough for everything before it.

Owen had noticed. "You look amazing," he'd said, coming up behind me at the mirror, still damp from the shower, pressing a kiss to my neck. "Big day?"

"Just the follow-up with the boutique hotel people. Making sure we're aligned on timeline."

"You'll be great." His hands had slid around my waist, and I'd let myself lean back against him for a moment, feeling the warmth of his body through his towel.

"I might be late," I'd said. "The meeting's at two-thirty, but I want to prep beforehand, maybe get some work done after."

"No worries. I'll probably work late too. This funding thing has us all scrambling."

Perfect. No timeline to account for. No expectations of when I'd be home.

Now I sat in my car in the Morrison Hotel parking garage, checking my reflection in the visor mirror one more time. Lipstick perfect, I'd switched to a deeper red today, something bolder. Hair falling just right. I looked like someone who had every right to be checking into a hotel at one in the afternoon on a Thursday.

I grabbed my purse and the small overnight bag I'd stashed in the trunk this morning, toothbrush, makeup remover, a change of underwear, the lacy black set I'd bought specifically for this. Owen thought I was at the office. The office thought I was prepping for the client meeting. Brady thought I was a woman named Natalie who had a roommate and a flexible schedule and wanted him badly enough to book expensive hotels.

Everyone had their version of the truth.

The lobby was all marble and brass, modern art on the walls, a massive flower arrangement on the center table, the kind of place that catered to business travelers and wealthy tourists, where no one looked twice at a beautiful woman checking in alone.

"Reservation for Natalie Chen," I said to the clerk, sliding my ID and credit card across the counter.

He processed everything efficiently, no judgment in his professional smile. "Room 847. Eighth floor. Elevators are to your right. Enjoy your stay."

"Thank you."

The elevator was mirrored on all sides. I watched myself rise through the building, eight versions of me, multiplied and reflected, each one perfectly composed. The numbers climbed: 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8.

The hallway was quiet, thickly carpeted, smelling faintly of expensive air freshener. Room 847 was at the end, and I swiped the key card, hearing the lock click open.

The room was nicer than our usual spot. King bed with crisp white linens, floor-to-ceiling windows with a view of the city, a sitting area with a velvet armchair, bathroom with a rainfall shower and marble countertops. I set my bag on the luggage rack and checked the time: 12:53.

Brady would be here in seven minutes. He was always exactly on time, punctual in that way that suggested he'd been waiting nearby, eager.

I freshened my lipstick in the bathroom, checked my teeth, adjusted my blouse so it draped just right. Then I texted him: *Room 847*

The three dots appeared immediately: *On my way up*

I could have sat in the armchair, played it cool and composed. Instead, I stood by the window, looking out at the city sprawled below, and felt that familiar electricity start to build. The anticipation. The knowledge that in a few minutes, Brady would walk through that door, and I would let him believe he was the only thing I wanted, and then in seventy-five minutes I would leave and go perform competence and professionalism for a client, and Owen would never know any of it.

The power of it was intoxicating.

A knock came at the door, soft but definite. I crossed the room slowly, let him wait for a beat, two beats, then opened it.

Brady stood there in dark jeans and a fitted t-shirt that showed off his build, gym bag over one shoulder, looking at me like I was the answer to a question he'd been asking all week. His eyes traveled down my body and back up, lingering.

"Fuck," he said, which wasn't eloquent but was gratifying.

I stepped back to let him in. He was on me before the door even clicked shut, dropping his bag, his hands finding my waist, my face, my hair, pulling me into a kiss that was hungry and urgent. I kissed him back, my fingers threading through his hair, letting him walk me backward toward the bed.

"You're overdressed," he murmured against my mouth, his hands already working at the buttons of my blouse.

"So fix it."

He did, fingers moving quickly, efficiently, pushing the silk off my shoulders and letting it fall to the floor. His hands found the clasp of my bra, black lace, the expensive kind, and I felt it give way, felt his breath catch as he looked at me.

"Jesus, Natalie."

I reached for his shirt, pulling it over his head, and ran my hands over his chest, his shoulders, feeling the solid muscle of him. So different from Owen's lean frame. So different from what waited for me at home.

He kissed me again, deeper this time, his tongue sliding against mine, his hands cupping my breasts, thumbs twisting my nipples in a way that made me arch into his touch. I felt myself responding, my body waking up to this, to him, to the wrongness of it that somehow made it feel more right.

"Bed," I said against his mouth, and he didn't need to be told twice.

Brady's hands went to my skirt, finding the button, the zipper, and I let him work at it while I kissed along his jaw, his neck, tasting the faint salt of his skin. He smelled like that cedar cologne he always wore, mixed with something clean, laundry detergent maybe, or just him. My skirt loosened and he pushed it down over my hips slowly, his palms sliding along my thighs as the fabric fell.

I stepped out of it, standing there in just my black lace underwear and my heels, and watched his face as he looked at me. This part never got old, the moment of appreciation, the visible want. His pupils were dilated, his breathing already uneven, and we hadn't even really started yet.

"You're unreal," he said, his voice rougher than usual.

I didn't respond with words. Instead, I reached for his belt, my fingers working the leather through the buckle with deliberate slowness. I could feel his stomach muscles tense under my knuckles as I pulled the belt free, let it drop to the floor with a soft thud. The button of his jeans next, then the zipper, and I could feel him hard against the denim, pressing forward.

He kicked off his shoes, nearly losing his balance, and I smiled at the gracelessness of it. The sex was always better when there was some awkwardness, some humanity. It made the rest of it feel more transgressive somehow.

I pushed his jeans down and he stepped out of them, standing there in just his boxer briefs, the outline of his erection obvious against the fabric. My hand went to him, pressing him through the cotton, and he made a sound low in his throat, his hips pushing forward into my touch.

"Natalie," he breathed, and there was something almost pleading in it.

But I wasn't ready to give him what he wanted yet. I liked this part, the building, the teasing, the control I had over his reactions. I kissed him again, slow and deep, while my hand continued its exploration, feeling him get harder under my palm.

His hands gripped my hips, fingers digging in, and he walked me backward until my legs hit the bed. I let myself fall back onto it, the

mattress firm and expensive beneath me, and he followed me down, his weight pressing me into the white duvet.

The windows behind us were floor-to-ceiling, the city visible beyond, and I thought distantly about whether anyone in the office buildings across the street could see us. The thought sent a small thrill through me, not enough to stop, just enough to sharpen everything.

Brady's mouth found my neck, my collarbone, the hollow of my throat. He kissed down between my breasts, his tongue tracing a line down my stomach, and his hands hooked into the sides of my underwear. No asking, Brady.

He pulled the lace down slowly, watching my face as he did it, and I lifted my hips to help him. The underwear joined the pile of clothes on the floor, my blouse, my skirt, his jeans, his shirt, evidence of what we were doing scattered across the expensive carpet.

I was naked except for my heels, and I didn't take them off. I knew how it looked, had seen myself like this in enough mirrors to know the effect.

Brady kissed the inside of my thigh, just above my knee, then higher, taking his time, building anticipation with each press of his lips against my skin. His hands slid up my legs, pushing them apart, and I let them fall open, let him settle between them.

His breath was warm against me for a moment before his mouth made contact, and I felt the first touch of his tongue, deliberate and sure. My back arched slightly off the bed, my hands finding the duvet and gripping it.

He worked slowly, methodically, like he had all the time in the world instead of the seventy-five minutes we'd carved out of our separate lives. His tongue moved in patterns I'd taught him over our previous encounters, I'd been specific about what I liked, unashamed about directing him, and he'd been a quick study.

My phone buzzed on the nightstand where I'd set it, the vibration loud against the wood. I turned my head to look at it, seeing Owen's name on the screen, and felt Brady pause.

"You need to get that?" he asked, his voice muffled.

"No," I said, not looking away from the phone. "Keep going."

He did, and I watched Owen's name disappear as the call went to voicemail, then reappear a moment later as a text notification. The contrast was almost artistic, Brady's mouth on me while Owen's name glowed on the screen, both of them wanting my attention in different ways.

I reached over and turned the phone face-down, eliminating the distraction.

Brady's fingers joined his tongue now, sliding inside me, and I made a sound that was half-gasp, half-moan. He was good at this. Better than Owen, if I was being honest, though Owen had other qualities that compensated. Owen was gentle, reverent, like making love to me was a privilege. Brady was confident, skilled, like he knew exactly what he was doing and expected to be good at it.

Both approaches had their appeal.

My hips started moving in rhythm with his mouth, my breathing getting shorter, and I could feel the pressure building. Not quite there yet, but heading in that direction, everything tightening and focusing down to the sensation of his tongue, his fingers, the wet heat of his mouth.

"Don't stop," I managed, and felt rather than saw him smile against me.

He didn't stop. He kept the same rhythm, the same pressure, reading my body's responses and adjusting infinitesimally, and I felt myself climbing higher, everything else falling away except this.

The city outside the windows. The expensive hotel room. Owen's message waiting on my phone. The client meeting in about an hour.

All of it dissolved into the singular focus of sensation, the building pressure that Brady was cultivating with his mouth, his hands, the deliberate attention he was giving to my body. My fingers had moved from the duvet to his hair, threading through it, not pulling but holding, keeping him exactly where I wanted him.

I could feel myself getting close, that edge approaching, and then my phone buzzed again.

Once. Twice. Three times in rapid succession.

The interruption broke my concentration just enough to pull me back from the brink, the orgasm receding like a wave. Frustration flared through me, sharp and immediate.

Brady felt the change in my body, the way I'd tensed differently, and he lifted his head. "You okay?"

"Fine," I said, the word coming out sharper than I intended. "Someone's just... it's fine. Keep going."

But the moment had fractured. He resumed what he'd been doing, and it still felt good, his tongue still knew where to go, his fingers still moved

inside me with that same confidence, but the building urgency had stalled out, plateaued.

I closed my eyes and tried to focus, tried to let myself sink back into it, but my mind kept snagging on the phone. Who was texting? Owen wouldn't text three times in a row unless something was wrong. Unless he needed something. Unless ...

Brady's rhythm faltered slightly, became less certain, and I realized he could sense my distraction.

"Hang on," I said, putting my hand on his shoulder.

He pulled back, his expression confused and a little hurt. "Did I do something wrong?"

"No. Just, one second."

I reached for my phone, and Brady sat back on his heels between my legs, waiting, his confusion deepening into something that looked like frustration. I flipped the phone over.

Four messages from Owen:

Hey! Quick question

The grant committee moved their review up. They want to see our preliminary data tonight instead of next week

I know this is last minute but any chance you could look at the presentation deck? You're so much better at the visual stuff than I am

It's okay if you're too busy! Just thought I'd ask

Relief and irritation washed through me in equal measure. Not an emergency. Just Owen being Owen, thinking of me even in the middle of his own crisis, trusting that I'd help if I could.

I typed back: *In a meeting right now but I can look at it later this afternoon. Send me the file*

The response came immediately: *You're the best. Thank you.*

I set the phone down again, face-down this time, and looked at Brady. He was still kneeling there, his erection visibly flagging inside his boxer briefs, his expression caught somewhere between aroused and annoyed.

"Sorry," I said. "Work thing."

"Right." He didn't sound convinced.

The moment had definitely broken. I could see it in his posture, feel it in the energy of the room. We'd have to rebuild from scratch, and I was suddenly, acutely aware of the time. Already one-forty. I had to be out of here, cleaned up, presentable, and across town by two-thirty.

I sat up and reached for him, pulling him toward me, kissing him with enough intensity to hopefully reset things. He responded, his hands finding my waist again, and I felt him start to harden against my stomach.

"Come here," I said against his mouth, shifting backward on the bed until I was against the pillows.

He followed, crawling over me, and I reached down to push his boxer briefs off. He kicked them away and pressed against me, skin to skin now, and I wrapped my legs around his waist.

"Do you have ..." he started.

"I'm on the pill," I said. "We're good."

This wasn't entirely true. I was on the pill, but Owen and I usually used condoms anyway, his caution overriding the single point of protection. But Brady didn't need to know that. Brady didn't need to know anything about Owen or what we did or didn't do.

He positioned himself at my entrance, and I felt the blunt pressure of him, and then he pushed inside slowly, his eyes locked on mine, watching my reaction.

I gasped. He was thicker than Owen, filled me differently, and I dug my nails into his shoulders. He groaned, his eyes falling shut, and started to move on me.

The rhythm was good, steady and deep, and I felt my body respond despite the earlier interruption. My hips rose to meet his, matching his pace, and his mouth found mine in a kiss that was more breathing into each other than actual kissing.

"God, you feel good," he muttered against my lips, and I made an agreeing sound, my hands sliding down his back.

He shifted the angle slightly, hitting deeper, and I moaned, genuine, not acted, and felt him smile against my neck.

"Don't stop."

He didn't. He kept that exact angle, that exact pace, and I felt everything starting to build again. My breathing got shorter, sharper, and my nails dragged down his back hard enough to leave marks.

The thought of marking him, of leaving evidence on his body the way he was leaving none on mine, sent a dark thrill through me. Owen would never see these scratches. Brady probably wouldn't even remember how he got them in a day or two. They'd fade into nothing, meaningless.

My phone buzzed again.

"Jesus Christ," Brady breathed, his rhythm stuttering.

"Ignore it," I said, gripping him tighter with my legs, forcing him to maintain the pace.

But he'd noticed it too now, the intrusion of the outside world into this expensive room, this stolen time. His focus had splintered, and I could feel it in the way he moved, less certain, more mechanical.

"Brady," I said, making my voice breathy, needy. "Please. I'm so close."

It was a lie, but it worked. His ego rallied, his movements becoming more purposeful again, and I made the sounds I knew he wanted to hear.

Brady's hand slid between our bodies, his thumb finding my clit, circling it with practiced pressure while he continued thrusting. The dual sensation was overwhelming in the right way, and I stopped having to fake my responses. My back arched off the bed, my head pressing back into the pillow, and I felt that coiling tension start to build again for real this time.

"That's it," he murmured, his voice strained. "Let me feel you."

His thumb kept that steady rhythm, and his hips drove forward harder now, deeper, the bed frame knocking softly against the wall with each thrust. I was climbing toward something, the pressure building in waves, each one higher than the last, and I could feel my body starting to tighten around him.

"Brady," I gasped, and it came out sounding desperate, which wasn't entirely manufactured.

"I got you," he said, and there was something almost tender in it that I didn't want, didn't need, but couldn't stop.

The high built and built, hovering right there at the edge, maddeningly close, and then my phone started actually ringing, not a text buzz but a full call, the ringtone loud in the quiet room.

"Fuck," Brady hissed, his rhythm breaking completely.

The tension shattered. Again. I could feel it dissolving, that peak receding out of reach, and fury flooded through me so intense it startled me with its force.

"Don't stop," I said through gritted teeth, but it was too late.

Brady had already slowed, his concentration broken, and the moment was gone. He was still hard inside me, still moving, but it was perfunctory now, mechanical. The phone continued ringing, Owen's ringtone, the one I'd set specifically for him, some classical piece he loved, and Brady's expression had shifted from focused to irritated.

"You should probably get that," he said.

"I really shouldn't."

But the damage was done. I could feel him starting to pull back emotionally even as he remained physically inside me, and I knew with absolute certainty that we weren't going to recover this. Not with the phone ringing, not with the time ticking away, not with whatever magic we'd managed to create earlier now completely dissipated.

The ringing stopped. Voicemail.

Brady's thrusts had become halfhearted, and I could see him starting to lose his erection, feel him softening slightly inside me. His jaw was tight with frustration, at the interruptions, at my distraction, at his own failing body.

"It's fine," I said, even though it wasn't. "Just... keep going."

He tried. I had to give him credit for trying. His hand went back between my legs, his thumb resuming its work, and he kissed my neck, my shoulder, trying to rebuild the intimacy. But we were both performing now, both pretending, and the authenticity had evaporated.

I made sounds that suggested I was enjoying it. He made sounds that suggested he was close. We moved together in a choreography that looked right from the outside but felt hollow.

After another minute, he pulled out abruptly. "This isn't working," he said, and there was an edge to his voice I hadn't heard before. "You're not here."

I sat up, pulling the sheet across my chest in a gesture that was more defensive than modest. "I am here."

"Your phone has gone off like six times. You keep tensing up every time it buzzes. You're obviously distracted."

"I'm not, "

"Natalie." He sat on the edge of the bed, his back to me, running his hands through his hair. "Look, I get it. You have a life. Things come up. But maybe we should just... call it for today."

The rejection stung in a way I hadn't anticipated. I was used to being the one in control, the one who decided when things started and stopped. Having Brady call it off felt like a loss of power, a shift in dynamics I didn't like.

"We still have time," I said, hating how my voice came out, almost pleading.

"Yeah, but your head's not in it." He stood up, retrieving his boxer briefs from the floor. "And honestly? Mine isn't either now."

I watched him dress, each piece of clothing he put on feeling like a small defeat. My blouse on the floor. My pants crumpled beside the bed. The black lace underwear that had cost sixty dollars and was supposed to drive him wild, discarded and pointless now.

"I'm sorry," I said, and was surprised to find I almost meant it. Not sorry for Owen, not sorry for the lying, but sorry that this moment, this carefully constructed moment, had fallen apart.

Brady pulled his shirt on and turned to look at me, his expression softer now but still guarded. "Shit happens." He paused, seeming to wrestle with something. "Can I ask you something?"

My guard went up immediately. "Sure."

"Is everything okay? With you, I mean. You seem... I don't know. Stressed, maybe?"

The irony of him asking this while I sat naked in a hotel bed, having just failed to have a successful affair with him, was not lost on me.

"I'm fine," I said, summoning my most convincing smile. "Work's just been intense. You know how it is."

"Yeah." He didn't sound convinced, but he also didn't push. "Look, I should probably head out. You've got your thing at two-thirty anyway, right?"

"Right."

He grabbed his gym bag, checked his pockets for his phone and wallet. At the door, he hesitated. "Text me later? When things calm down?"

"Of course."

He left, and I sat there in the expensive hotel room, surrounded by rumpled sheets and discarded clothing and the heavy silence of failure. The clock on the nightstand read 2:05.

I'd paid for the room. I could have stayed, used the time to decompress, to shower, to restore myself to presentability. Instead, I felt restless, unsettled, like my skin was crawling with unspent energy.

I got up and walked to the window, pressed my palm against the cool glass, looking down at the city below. People moved along sidewalks, cars idled at red lights, the whole mechanism of ordinary life turning without any awareness of me standing here naked and furious in room 847.

The fury surprised me with its intensity. I should have felt embarrassed, maybe. Disappointed. Instead, I felt cheated. Robbed of something that was supposed to be mine, the climax, the satisfaction, the triumphant feeling of getting away with it perfectly.

Owen had ruined it. Not intentionally, he didn't even know there was anything to ruin, but his need for my help, his innocent trust that I'd be available, his fucking grant presentation had destroyed what should have been a perfect afternoon.

I picked up my phone from the nightstand. Seven messages now. Three more had come in while Brady and I had been attempting to salvage things.

Owen: *Sorry to bug you again*

Owen: *Actually don't worry about the deck. Derek said he can handle the visuals*

Owen: *Just saw you're in a meeting. Call me when you're free? Miss you*

The casual affection in that last message made something twist in my chest. Not guilt, I'd examined that feeling enough to know what guilt actually felt like, and this wasn't it. More like... resentment. Resentment that he could miss me while I was here, that he could derail my plans without even knowing he'd done it.

I typed back: *Meeting wrapped early. I can look at the deck if you still need me to*

The response was immediate: *No no, we're all set. Derek's got it. How did your thing go?*

My thing. My fictional prep session for the fictional client meeting that wasn't for another twenty minutes.

Me: *Good. Really productive*

Owen: *Excellent. You're going to crush the actual meeting. Love you*

Me: *Love you too*

I set the phone down and stared at it like it was a live thing that might bite. Then I gathered my clothes from the floor, putting myself back together piece by piece. The black lace underwear. The pants. The blouse with its delicate buttons. Each item of clothing felt like armor going back on, restoring me to my public self.

In the bathroom, I assessed the damage. My makeup had held up reasonably well, smudged mascara under one eye that I fixed with a damp tissue. My lipstick completely gone, kissed away, and I reapplied it carefully, the same deep red from this morning. My hair was messier, that

just-fucked look that actually looked good but wasn't appropriate for a client meeting. I smoothed it down, tucked it behind my ears, made it professional again.

The woman looking back at me from the mirror looked composed. Successful. Like someone who'd spent the last hour productively preparing for an important meeting, not failing to have decent sex with her boyfriend's... what was Brady, exactly? Not her boyfriend's friend. Not anyone who mattered in her real life. Just a man. Just a body. Just a way to feel something.

I packed up the overnight bag, the toothbrush unused, the makeup remover unnecessary, the change of underwear still folded and pristine. Evidence of a plan that hadn't worked out.

Back in the room, I did a final sweep. Nothing left behind. No earrings on the nightstand, no hair ties on the bathroom counter. I'd learned to be thorough.

The bed was a disaster, sheets twisted and pulled loose from the corners, pillows scattered. For a moment, I considered making it, restoring it to its original pristine state. Then I decided against it. Let housekeeping deal with it. Let them see the evidence and draw their own conclusions. They'd never know the real story anyway.

I left room 847 at 2:15, pulling the door shut behind me with a firm click.

The elevator ride down was interminable. I watched the numbers descend, 8, 7, 6, and checked my reflection in the mirrored walls one more time. Perfect. No one would ever know.

The lobby was busier than when I'd arrived. A group of businesspeople checking in, loud and jovial. A couple with matching luggage having some quiet argument near the concierge desk. I walked through it all like I belonged, like I had every right to be there, and no one gave me a second glance.

In my car, I sat for a moment with the engine running, the air conditioning blasting cold against my face. My hands were steady on the steering wheel. My reflection in the rearview mirror showed someone calm and collected.

But underneath, something felt off. Wrong. Like a piece of machinery that had been running smoothly and suddenly developed a grinding noise, almost imperceptible but definitely there.

I pulled out of the parking garage and into traffic, heading toward the client's office. The meeting was at their headquarters downtown, a glass tower that reflected the afternoon sun like a mirror. I found parking in the adjacent garage, gathered my laptop bag and presentation materials, and made my way to the building.

The elevator up to the fourteenth floor was crowded with people heading back from late lunches. I stood in the back corner, my laptop bag clutched against my chest, and no one looked at me. No one knew.

Sharon's assistant met me in the lobby of their floor, a bright, minimalist space with their logo displayed in brushed steel letters on the wall.

"Natalie! So good to see you again."

"You too, Melissa."

"Sharon's running about five minutes behind, but we've got the conference room all set up for you. Can I get you some water? Coffee?"

"Water would be great, thank you."

The conference room had floor-to-ceiling windows overlooking the city, the same view I'd had from the hotel room less than an hour ago. Different angle, same urban sprawl. I connected my laptop to their presentation screen and pulled up the deck I'd perfected earlier this week.

My hands were steady. My breathing was even. I looked exactly like someone who'd spent her afternoon preparing for this moment.

Sharon arrived with two members of her team, a marketing manager named Brett and someone from their creative department whose name I'd been told but immediately forgot. We shook hands, exchanged pleasantries about the weather, the traffic, how quickly the week was going. I smiled at the right moments, made eye contact, played the role of competent professional with practiced ease.

"So," Sharon said, settling into her chair at the head of the table, "walk us through where we are with implementation."

I launched into the presentation, clicking through slides, explaining timelines and deliverables and strategic touch-points. My voice was clear and confident. I anticipated their questions before they asked them. When Brett pushed back on the budget allocation for social media, I had data ready to support my recommendation.

This was what I was good at, reading a room, adjusting my approach, giving people what they needed to feel confident in their decision. Not so

different from what I did with Owen, really. Or Brady. Just a different kind of play.

The meeting went forty-five minutes. They approved everything. Sharon walked me to the elevator herself, thanking me for my flexibility, my vision, my partnership.

"You really get what we're trying to build here," she said. "That's rare."

"I'm just excited to be part of it," I said, and it sounded genuine because I'd made it sound genuine.

In the elevator, alone, I finally let my face relax. Let the smile drop. Let my shoulders come down from where they'd been held in perfect posture. The descent to the parking garage was long enough for me to close my eyes and just breathe.

My phone showed a text from Miranda: *How'd it go?*

Me: *Perfect. They loved everything*

Miranda: *That's my girl. See you tomorrow*

And one from Owen, from twenty minutes ago: *Presentation went great! Committee seemed really impressed. Fingers crossed for the funding. Hope your meeting is going well*

I stared at that heart emoji for a long moment. Such a small thing. Such an automatic appendage to a text message. Did he even think about it when he added it, or was it just muscle memory at this point? Did it mean anything?

Did any of it mean anything?

I drove home on autopilot, following familiar streets, stopping at familiar red lights. The radio played something I didn't listen to. My mind was elsewhere, circling around the afternoon, examining it from different angles like a problem to solve.

The failure bothered me more than it should have. Not the lack of orgasm, that happens sometimes. But the loss of control. The way Brady had taken agency, had decided to stop, had rejected the moment. That wasn't how this was supposed to work.

Our apartment building appeared ahead, and I pulled into my usual spot. Checked my face in the mirror one more time, fine, normal, no evidence of anything. Grabbed my laptop bag and headed upstairs.

Owen's car wasn't in the lot. Still at the lab, probably, riding the high of a successful presentation, talking through next steps with his team. I'd have the apartment to myself for at least another hour.

Inside, everything was exactly as we'd left it this morning. Owen's coffee mug in the sink, rinsed but not washed. The blanket from last night still draped over the couch. My jewelry on the dresser where I'd left it.

I set my laptop bag down and stood in the quiet apartment, feeling the weight of the day settle over me. The hotel room. Brady's frustration. The client meeting. The performance after performance after performance.

I should shower. Wash away any trace of Brady, of the afternoon. But instead, I walked to the bedroom and lay down on the bed, our bed, mine and Owen's, still fully dressed, staring up at that water stain on the ceiling.

My phone buzzed. I lifted it to see Brady's name.

Brady: *Hey. Sorry about today. Rain check?*

I turned the phone face-down on my chest and closed my eyes.

The thing was, I could stop this anytime I wanted. That's what I told myself. This wasn't an addiction or a compulsion. It was a choice, and I was choosing it, which meant I could choose differently. I could text Brady right now and end it. Block his number. Delete our message thread. Stop going to the climbing gym. Return to the simple monogamy that Owen believed we had.

I could do that. I just didn't want to.

The front door opened. I heard Owen's keys hit the bowl on the entry table, his bag thump onto the floor, his footsteps heading toward the bedroom.

"Hey, you," he said, appearing in the doorway, and his whole face lit up the way it always did when he saw me. "How was the rest of your day?"

I sat up, arranging my expression into something warm and welcoming. "Good. Productive. How was the presentation?"

"Really good, I think. Derek absolutely nailed his part, and the committee asked great questions, which usually means they're actually interested." He came over and sat on the edge of the bed, taking my hand. "Thanks for offering to look at the deck earlier. I know you were busy."

"Of course. Anytime."

He squeezed my hand, studying my face with that careful attention he gave to problems he was trying to solve. "You look tired. Long day?"

"A little," I admitted. This, at least, was true.

"Want to order in? We could do that Thai place you love, watch something mindless, just decompress."

It sounded perfect. It sounded exactly like what a good girlfriend would want after a long day at work. And I did want it, in a way. The comfort of it, the easy predictability.

"That sounds great," I said.

Owen leaned in and kissed me, soft and sweet, and I kissed him back, tasting coffee and chapstick and trust. When he pulled away, he was smiling.

"I'll order. You want your usual?"

"Please."

He left to find his phone, and I heard him in the kitchen, calling in our order, his voice carrying back to me in fragments: "...yeah, the pad see ew, extra peanut sauce, that's great, thanks!"